Deck 04 · Optimization I: descent, Newton, Gauss-Newton, and the damped inverse-kinematics step

3.1 Descent, step size, and the safety check

3.2 Newton, Gauss-Newton, and the damped step

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Given φ and $\mathbf{J}$, how do we find $\mathbf{q}$ with $\varphi(\mathbf{q}) = \mathbf{y}^*$?
When does the obvious full step fail, what check protects against it, and what better step replaces it?

Where Deck 03's bridge left us

quantity	value
target $\mathbf{y}^*$	$(0.5,\ 0.2)$ m
start $\mathbf{q}^{(0)}$	$(30^\circ,\ 45^\circ)$
tip $\varphi(\mathbf{q}^{(0)})$	$(0.4241,\ 0.4898)$ m
$\mathbf{e} = \mathbf{y}^* - \varphi(\mathbf{q}^{(0)})$	$(0.0759,\ -0.2898)$ m
step solving $\mathbf{J}\Delta\mathbf{q} = \mathbf{e}$	$(-52.7^\circ,\ 74.1^\circ)$
miss after that step	0.17 m

Left open

- How far to trust the step
- A 3×7 $\mathbf{J}$ (the Panda)
- What if the robot cannot reach the target?

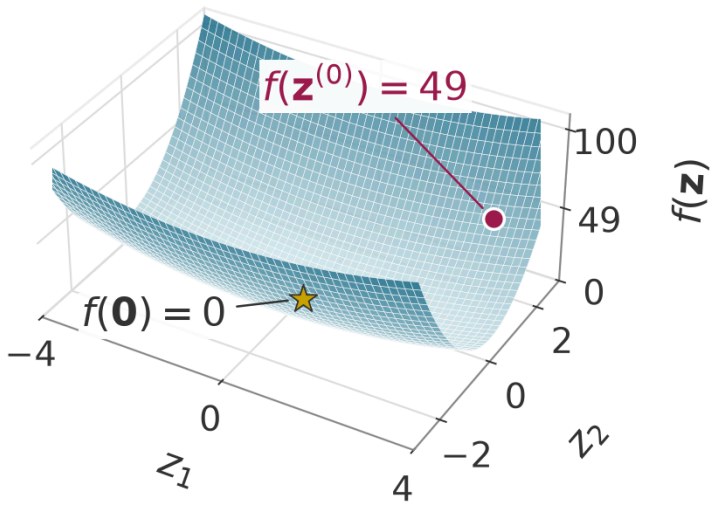
A scalar cost and methods that walk downhill on it answer all three.

$$\min_{\mathbf{q}} \ f(\mathbf{q}) = \tfrac{1}{2}\|\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\|^2, \qquad \mathbf{r}(\mathbf{q}) := \varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*, \qquad \mathbf{r}(\mathbf{q}^{(0)}) = -\mathbf{e}$$

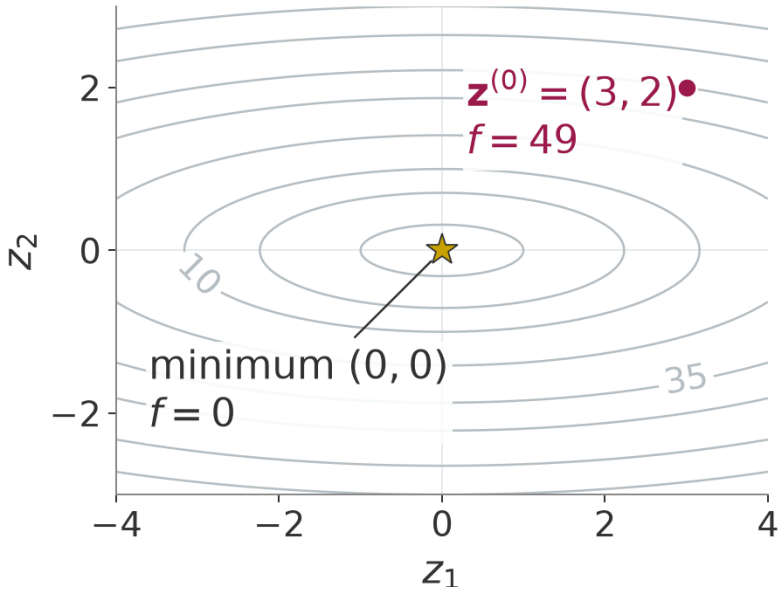
See the cost as a surface

$$f(\mathbf{z}) = z_1^2 + 10z_2^2, \qquad \mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^2, \qquad \mathbf{z}^{(0)} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}$$

Height gives the cost



Each contour has one cost

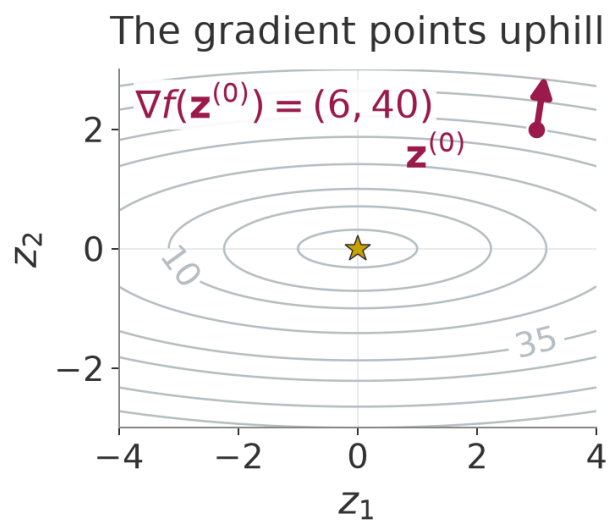


Current cost: $f(3, 2) = 3^2 + 10(2^2) = 49$

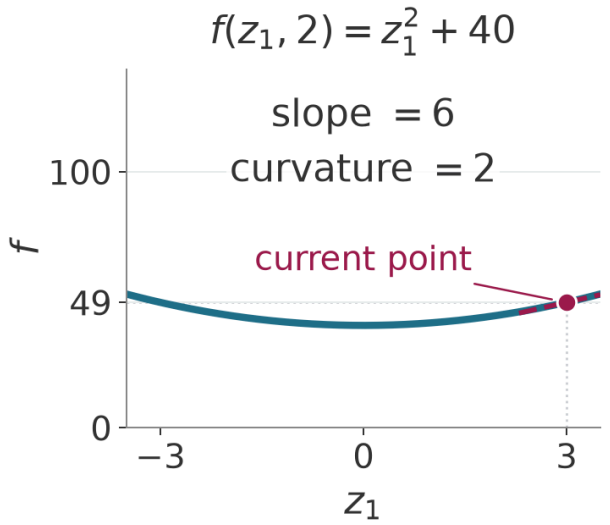
Minimum: $(0, 0)$, cost 0 · **Contours:** equal cost

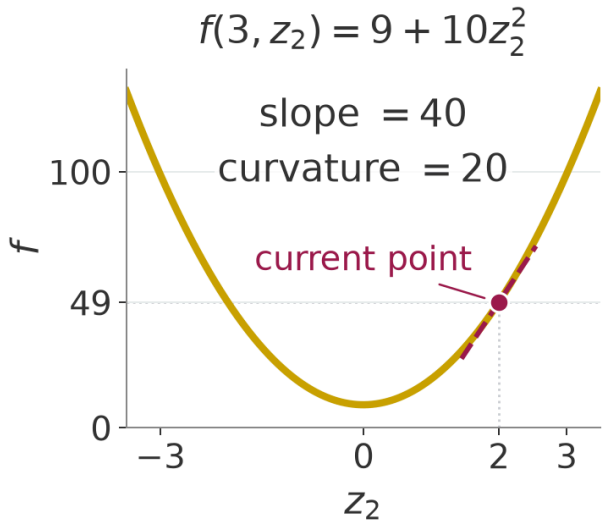
modules/opt-explorer · optional ▶ **inspect the bowl**

Read slope and curvature at the same point



Arrow scaled for visibility.
It is not a step.





Both slices use the same axis scales.

Gradient: the two slopes, stacked; points uphill

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{z}) = \begin{bmatrix} 2z_1 \\ 20z_2 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad \nabla f(3, 2) = \begin{bmatrix} 6 \\ 40 \end{bmatrix}$$

Hessian: changes of those slopes

$$H_{ij} = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial z_i \partial z_j}, \qquad \mathbf{H} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 20 \end{bmatrix}$$

$\mathbf{H} \succ 0$ (**positive definite**): upward curvature in every direction

The local model, and what "local" costs

$$\min_{\mathbf{z}\in\mathbb{R}^d} f(\mathbf{z}), \qquad f(\mathbf{z}+\boldsymbol{\delta}) \approx f(\mathbf{z}) + \nabla f^\top \boldsymbol{\delta} + \tfrac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{\delta}^\top \mathbf{H}\boldsymbol{\delta}$$

- Deck 03 linearized a vector map, $\varphi(\mathbf{q}+\Delta\mathbf{q}) \approx \varphi(\mathbf{q}) + \mathbf{J}\Delta\mathbf{q}$; this is the same expansion for a scalar, kept one term further, with the step $\Delta\mathbf{q}$ written $\boldsymbol{\delta}$
- Today: $\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{q}$, the n joint angles
- Week 4: $\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{q}_{0:T}$, a whole trajectory
- **Local search** is like a walker on a hillside in fog, sensing nearby ground. Different starts can reach different valleys; a run may stop at a saddle or fail to converge. No global-minimum certificate

modules/opt-explorer · optional ▶ **compare starting points**

Two decisions per step

$$\mathbf{z} \leftarrow \mathbf{z} + \alpha\,\mathbf{d}$$

- **Where to move:** downhill direction $\mathbf{d}$
- **How far to move:** scale $\mathbf{d}$ by $\alpha > 0$
- Gradient descent: $\mathbf{d} = -\nabla f(\mathbf{z})$
- Newton: $\mathbf{d} = -\mathbf{H}^{-1}\nabla f(\mathbf{z})$ (slide 17 derives it)

Wanted from the method

- **monotone**: f never increases
- **convergent**: $\|\nabla f\| \to 0$ (conditions in the notes)
- **robust**: rescaling $\mathbf{z}$ does not slow it

modules/opt-explorer · optional ▶ **inspect direction and step**

Compute a gradient-descent step

$$f(\mathbf{z}) = z_1^2 + 10z_2^2, \qquad \nabla f(\mathbf{z}) = (2z_1,\ 20z_2)$$

1. Subtract the scaled slope.

$$\begin{aligned} z_1 &\leftarrow z_1 - \alpha(2z_1) \\ &= (1 - 2\alpha)z_1, \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} z_2 &\leftarrow z_2 - \alpha(20z_2) \\ &= (1 - 20\alpha)z_2. \end{aligned}$$

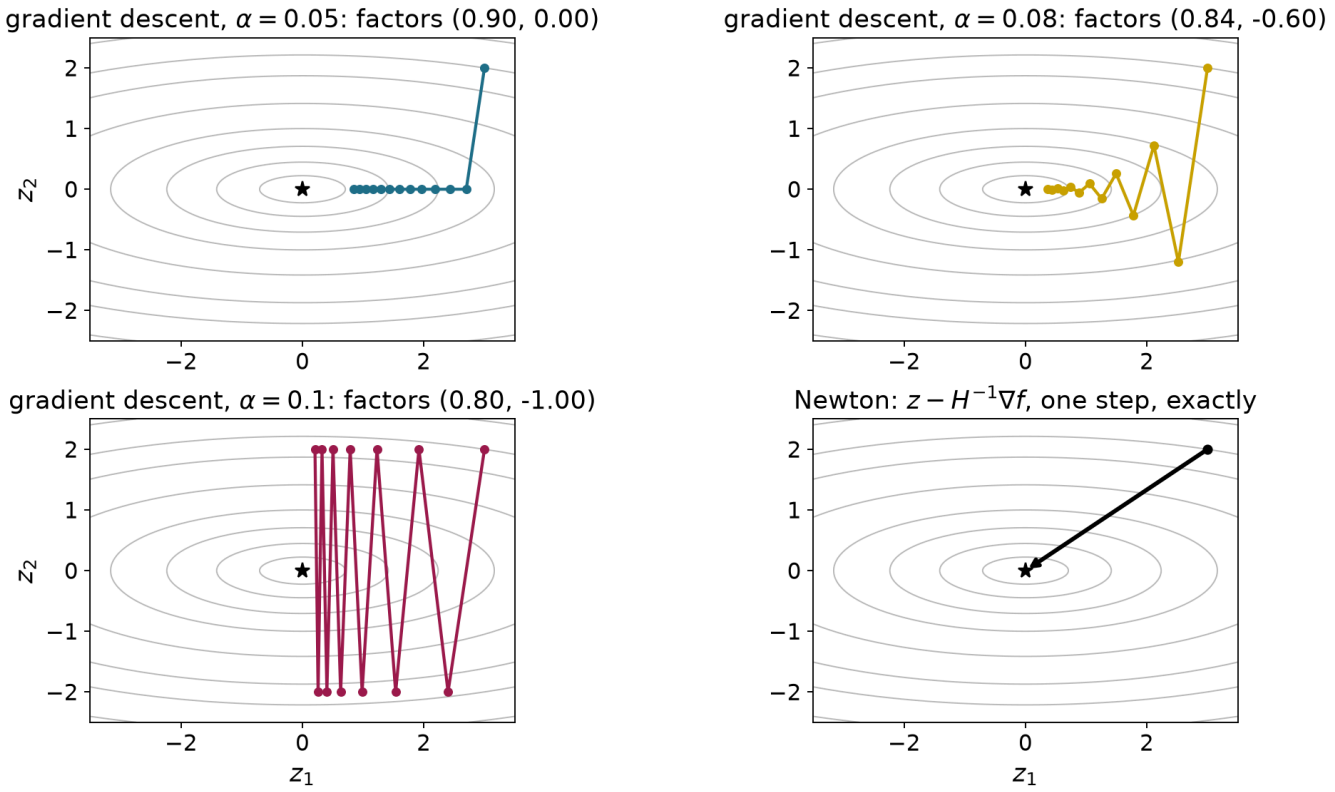
2. Compare step sizes from $(3, 2)$.

α	factors on (z_1, z_2)	next point
0.05	$(0.9, 0)$	$(2.7, 0)$
0.5	$(0, -9)$	$(0, -18)$

- 0.05: z_2 at zero; z_1 closer
- 0.5: z_1 at zero; z_2 overshoots

No single α takes both to zero in one step.

Three step sizes, and Newton's one step



$f(\mathbf{z}) = z_1^2 + 10z_2^2$ from $(3, 2)$, twelve steps: larger α speeds z_1 but can make z_2 oscillate

code/descent.py · modules/opt-explorer ▶ **compare step sizes**

Balance the two coordinate updates

1. Compare the curvatures (eigenvalues of $\mathbf{H}$).

$$\lambda_{\min} = 2, \qquad \lambda_{\max} = 20, \qquad \operatorname{cond}(\mathbf{H}) = \frac{\lambda_{\max}}{\lambda_{\min}} = \frac{20}{2} = 10$$

Condition number: steepest / flattest curvature

2. Make the larger factor magnitude as small as possible.

Equal factor magnitudes, opposite signs

$$1 - 2\alpha = -(1 - 20\alpha) \quad \Rightarrow \quad 2 = 22\alpha \quad \Rightarrow \quad \alpha^* = \frac{1}{11} \approx 0.0909$$

3. Repeat this fixed step.

$$z_1 \leftarrow \frac{9}{11} z_1, \qquad z_2 \leftarrow -\frac{9}{11} z_2 \quad \Rightarrow \quad f_{\text{next}} = \frac{81}{121} f \approx 0.669 f$$

From cost 49: **45 steps** to cost below 10^{-6}.

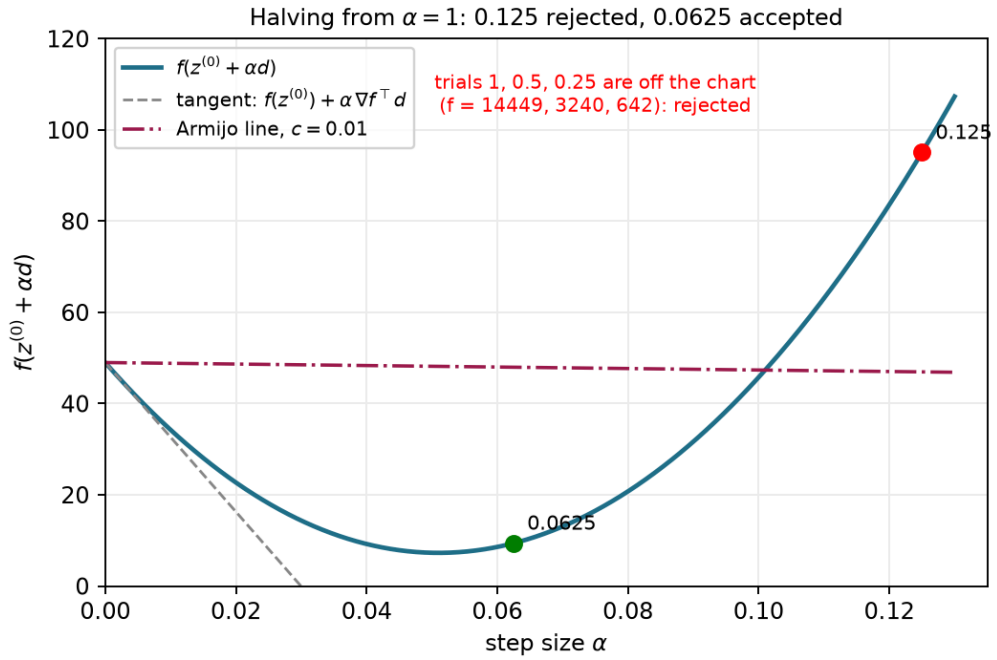
Larger curvature mismatch: slower progress in the slowest direction

Armijo's check chooses the step size

$$f(\mathbf{z} + \alpha \mathbf{d}) \;\leq\; f(\mathbf{z}) + c\,\alpha\,\nabla f(\mathbf{z})^{\top}\mathbf{d}, \qquad c = 0.01$$

- The best fixed α needs $\lambda_{\min}$ and $\lambda_{\max}$, which a real cost does not tell you and which change with $\mathbf{z}$
- Accept the step only if f falls by at least the fraction c of the drop that the tangent line predicts
- If not: **halve α and try again**. If yes: take the step, grow α by 1.2 for next time.
- For a smooth cost and a strict descent direction, unlimited backtracking terminates; accepted steps make descent **monotone**

Backtracking at $\mathbf{z}^{(0)} = (3, 2)$



- $\mathbf{d} = -\nabla f = (-6, -40)$
- threshold $= 49 - 16.36\,\alpha$

α	$f(\mathbf{z}^{(0)} + \alpha\mathbf{d})$	**threshold**	
1	14 449	32.6	reject
0.5	3 240	40.8	reject
0.25	642	44.9	reject
0.125	95.1	47.0	reject
0.0625	**9.4**	48.0	**accept**

step	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
accepted α	**0.0625**	0.075	0.09	0.108	0.13	0.078

The search adapts α at each point.

code/descent.py · modules/opt-explorer **▶ inspect Armijo steps**

The algorithm, and what is left out

```
α ← 1
repeat
    d ← −∇f(z)
    while f(z + α d) > f(z) + c α ∇f(z)ᵀ d:              # Armijo backtracking
        if α <= floor: stop, report "stalled"            # floor 10⁻⁶
        α ← α / 2
    s ← α d;  z ← z + s                                  # the accepted step
    α ← 1.2 α                                            # grow for the next trial
until |s| < tolerance  or  |∇f(z)| < tolerance
```

A short accepted step means slow progress, not proven stationarity; a small gradient means approximate stationarity. Say which test stopped the run (slide 28).

In the backup slides at the end of this deck: Wolfe's curvature condition and bracket-and-zoom; quasi-Newton (BFGS, L-BFGS); conjugate gradients.

Live demo: the optimization explorer

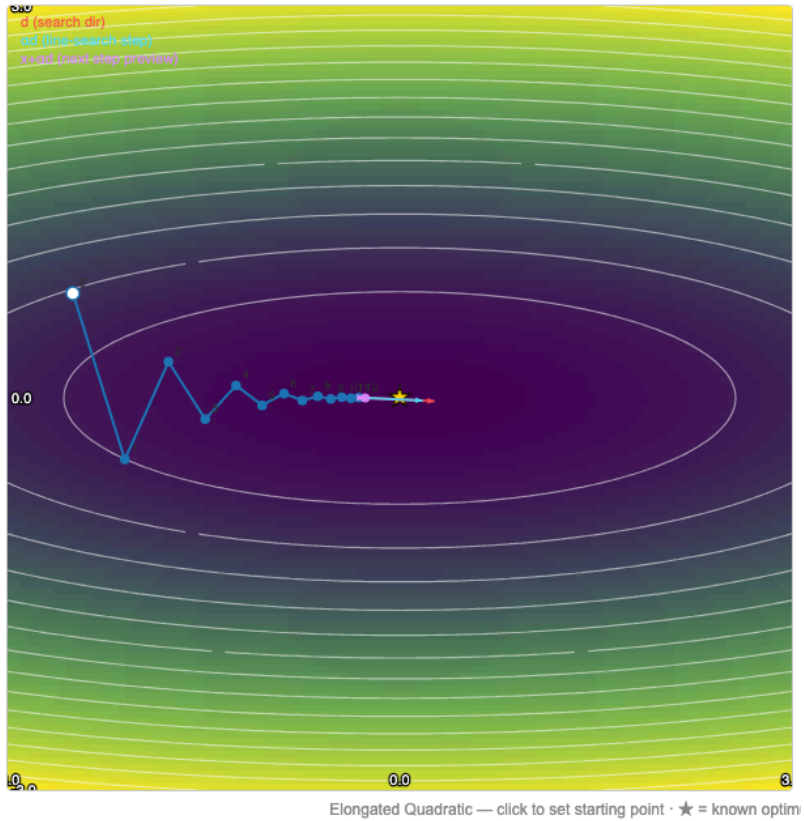
1 · Line search Off, gradient descent

slider α	before Step
0.050	try
0.079	try
0.100	try
0.110	predict, then run

2 · Line search Armijo, slider $\alpha = 1.000$

Compare "α used" with slide 11

3 · Line search Off, method **Newton**: one Step



modules/opt-explorer · Unconstrained tab ▶ run it live

Back to the arm: one gradient step

$$f(\mathbf{q}) = \tfrac{1}{2}\|\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\|^2 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \nabla f(\mathbf{q}) = \mathbf{J}(\mathbf{q})^\top \big(\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\big)$$

$\mathbf{q}^{(0)}$	$\mathbf{y}^*$	∇f (m²/rad, checked by finite differences)
$(30^\circ, 45^\circ)$	$(0.5, 0.2)$	$(0.160,\ 0.045)$

	$\mathbf{q}$ (deg)	tip (m)	$\|\varphi - \mathbf{y}^*\|$
start	(30.0, 45.0)	(0.424, 0.490)	0.300 m
one step, $\alpha = 1$ accepted by Armijo	(20.8, 42.4)	(0.509, 0.410)	0.210 m

Stepping against this gradient is called **Jacobian-transpose inverse kinematics**. Armijo makes the step size safe.

code/gauss_newton_ik.py · modules/gauss-newton-ik ▶ run it live

Summary of 3.1

- Inverse kinematics becomes $\min_{\mathbf{q}} \frac{1}{2}\|\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\|^2$, gradient $\mathbf{J}^\top(\varphi - \mathbf{y}^*)$: one gradient step took the tip from 30 cm to 21 cm off
- Gradient descent: the steepest curvature limits α
- Quadratic, fixed step: $\mathrm{cond}(\mathbf{H})$ controls the worst-direction rate
- **Armijo backtracking:** choose α per step; require sufficient cost decrease

bowl	$\mathrm{cond}(\mathbf{H})$	steps
today's	10	45
a narrow valley	100	443
the arm near its solution	8.2	56 (notes §4.2)

Break

Second half: use the curvature, then use the structure of the cost.

Newton uses curvature to choose the step

Fit a quadratic model around the current configuration:

$$m(\boldsymbol{\delta}) = f(\mathbf{z}) + \nabla f^\top \boldsymbol{\delta} + \tfrac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{\delta}^\top \mathbf{H}\boldsymbol{\delta}$$

If the model curves upward in every direction, its minimum gives the **Newton step**:

$$\mathbf{H}\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\nabla f$$

- For an upward-curving quadratic cost, one full step reaches the minimum
- For a nonlinear robot cost, check the actual result and rebuild the local model

modules/opt-explorer · optional ▶ **inspect the local model**

Damping can correct an uphill Newton direction

A quadratic model can curve downward. Its stationary point need not minimize it.

Add enough positive curvature to make the model curve upward:

$$(\mathbf{H} + \rho\mathbf{I})\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\nabla f$$

Live example: a cost with a maximum at the origin, starting at $(0.1, 0.1)$.

step	lands at	direction
Newton, $\rho = 0$	$(-0.002, -0.002)$	uphill, toward the maximum
damped, $\rho = 10$	$(0.165, 0.165)$	downhill

A downhill direction still needs an **actual-cost check**.

modules/opt-explorer · Unconstrained tab ▶ run it live

Gauss–Newton approximates Newton's curvature

Minimize the robot's squared tip error:

$$\min_{\mathbf{q}} \; f(\mathbf{q}) = \tfrac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{r}(\mathbf{q})\|^2, \qquad \mathbf{r}(\mathbf{q}) := \varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*$$

First derivative, then second derivative:

$$\nabla f = \mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{r}$$

$$\mathbf{H} = \underbrace{\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{J}_r}_{\text{Gauss–Newton keeps this}} + \underbrace{\sum_j r_j \nabla^2 r_j}_{\text{Gauss–Newton drops this}}$$

- Small residuals often make the omitted curvature small
- Persistent residuals can make that curvature important

Gauss–Newton reduces the predicted error

Reuse differential IK's Jacobian: choose a **joint displacement** instead of a velocity.

Minimize the predicted squared error for one step:

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\delta}} \ \tfrac{1}{2}\left\|\mathbf{r} + \mathbf{J}_r\boldsymbol{\delta}\right\|^2$$

Setting the model's gradient to zero gives the **Gauss–Newton step**:

$$(\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{J}_r)\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{r}$$

For IK, the Jacobian is the same, and the residual reverses Deck 03's displacement:

$$\mathbf{J}_r = \mathbf{J}, \qquad \mathbf{r} = \varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^* = -\mathbf{e}$$

Damping makes the proposed step more cautious

$$(\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{J}_r + \rho \mathbf{I})\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{r}$$

Same arm, target, and start, with slide 18's damping idea:

first step	undamped	damping $\rho = 0.05$
elbow change	74.1°	11.5°
actual tip error after the step	0.174 m	0.115 m

- Penalizes large joint changes; positive damping makes the system invertible
- With strong damping, curvature has less influence, and the update approaches a short negative-gradient step
- Fixed damping can slow progress, especially along weak task-motion directions

Levenberg–Marquardt (LM): adaptive damping

Levenberg–Marquardt (LM) adapts damping as the local model is rebuilt.

For a trial with a predicted cost decrease:

$$\eta_{\mathrm{LM}} = \frac{\text{actual cost decrease}}{\text{predicted cost decrease}}$$

What the trial reveals	How the solver responds
Ratio near one or larger	Useful prediction; damping can decrease
Small positive ratio	Optimistic prediction; increase damping
Actual cost increases	Reject the step; retry with more damping

Still a local method: reaching the target is not guaranteed.

opt-explorer · Trajectory tab ▶ **inspect adaptive damping**

Inverse kinematics as least squares

The task objective

$$\min_{\mathbf{q}} \ \tfrac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{r}(\mathbf{q})\|_{\mathbf{K}}^2$$

$\mathbf{K}$ weights task-error components.

The model for one step

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\delta}} \ \tfrac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{r} + \mathbf{J}\boldsymbol{\delta}\|_{\mathbf{K}}^2 + \tfrac{1}{2}\|\boldsymbol{\delta}\|_{\mathbf{D}}^2$$

The same $\mathbf{K}$ weights predicted task error; $\mathbf{D}$ weights the joint change directly.

Here the residual and Jacobian are evaluated at the current configuration. For the task error:

$$\|\mathbf{r}\|_{\mathbf{K}}^2 = \mathbf{r}^\top \mathbf{K}\mathbf{r}$$

The step penalty discourages large updates from the current configuration. A posture cost favors staying near a fixed reference posture.

Damped Gauss–Newton for inverse kinematics

Solve for the joint change using the current error and Jacobian:

$$(\mathbf{J}^\top \mathbf{K} \mathbf{J} + \mathbf{D})\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\mathbf{J}^\top \mathbf{K} \mathbf{r}$$

The same mapping, when the step matrix is invertible:

$$\mathbf{J}^\sharp = (\mathbf{J}^\top \mathbf{K} \mathbf{J} + \mathbf{D})^{-1} \mathbf{J}^\top \mathbf{K}, \qquad \boldsymbol{\delta} = -\mathbf{J}^\sharp \mathbf{r}$$

1. Compute the tip error and Jacobian
2. Solve for a proposed joint change
3. Check the **actual cost** with Armijo; shorten the trial if needed
4. Update the joints, rebuild the model, and repeat

Four faces of the same step

$\mathbf{K}$	$\mathbf{D}$	$\mathbf{J}^\sharp$	what it is
any ($\mathbf{J}$ square, invertible)	0	$\mathbf{J}^{-1}$	Undamped Gauss–Newton with an invertible Jacobian; the same inverse as differential IK
$\mathbf{I}$	0	$\mathbf{J}^+ (= \mathbf{J}^\top(\mathbf{J}\mathbf{J}^\top)^{-1}$ at full row rank)	Undamped least squares; the pseudoinverse selects the update with the **smallest sum of squared joint changes** among equally good task corrections.
$\mathbf{I}$	$\rho\mathbf{I}$	$(\mathbf{J}^\top\mathbf{J} + \rho\mathbf{I})^{-1}\mathbf{J}^\top$	slide 21's damped step with $\mathbf{J}_r = \mathbf{J}$, since $-\mathbf{J}_r^\top\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{J}^\top(\mathbf{y}^* - \varphi)$
general	general $\succ 0$	$(\mathbf{J}^\top\mathbf{K}\mathbf{J} + \mathbf{D})^{-1}\mathbf{J}^\top\mathbf{K}$	Weighted, damped Gauss–Newton

Compare the IK step choices from the same configuration.

Repeat the step to solve inverse kinematics

Target: $\mathbf{y}^* = (0.5, 0.2)$ m

start	value
$\mathbf{q}^{(0)}$	$(30^\circ, 45^\circ)$
tip $\varphi(\mathbf{q}^{(0)})$	$(0.4241, 0.4898)$ m
task cost $f(\mathbf{q}^{(0)})$	0.0449 m²

$$f(\mathbf{q}) = \tfrac{1}{2}\|\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\|^2$$

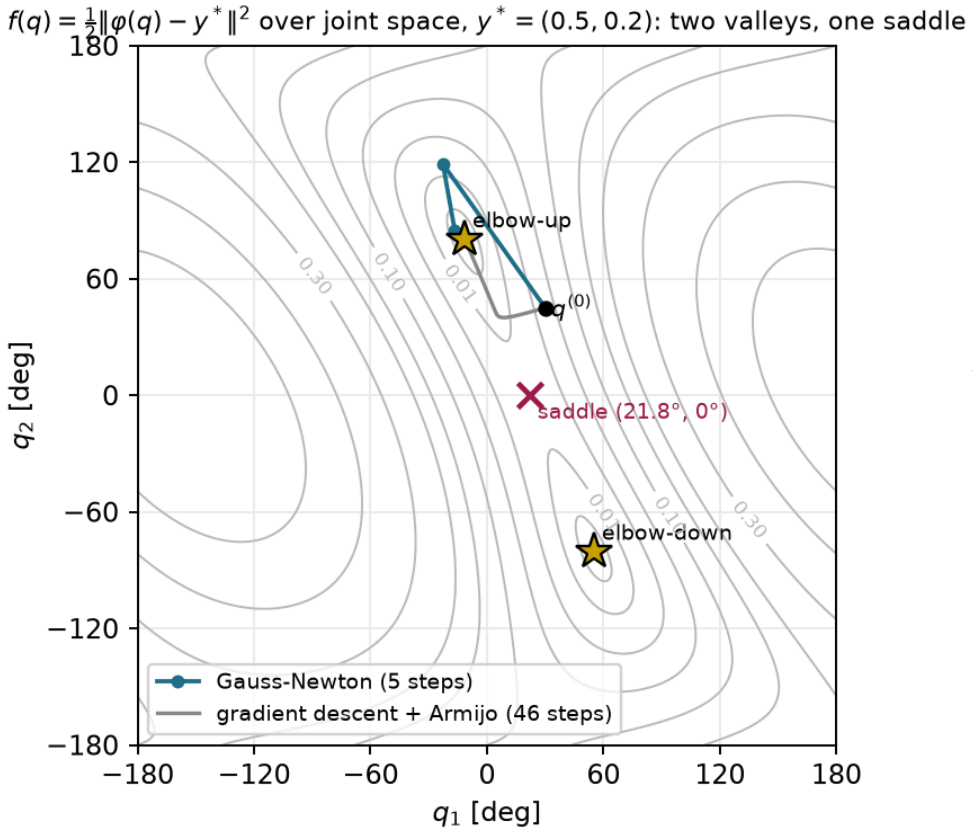
1. Compute the current error and Jacobian.
2. Solve for a joint correction.
3. Update the configuration and repeat.

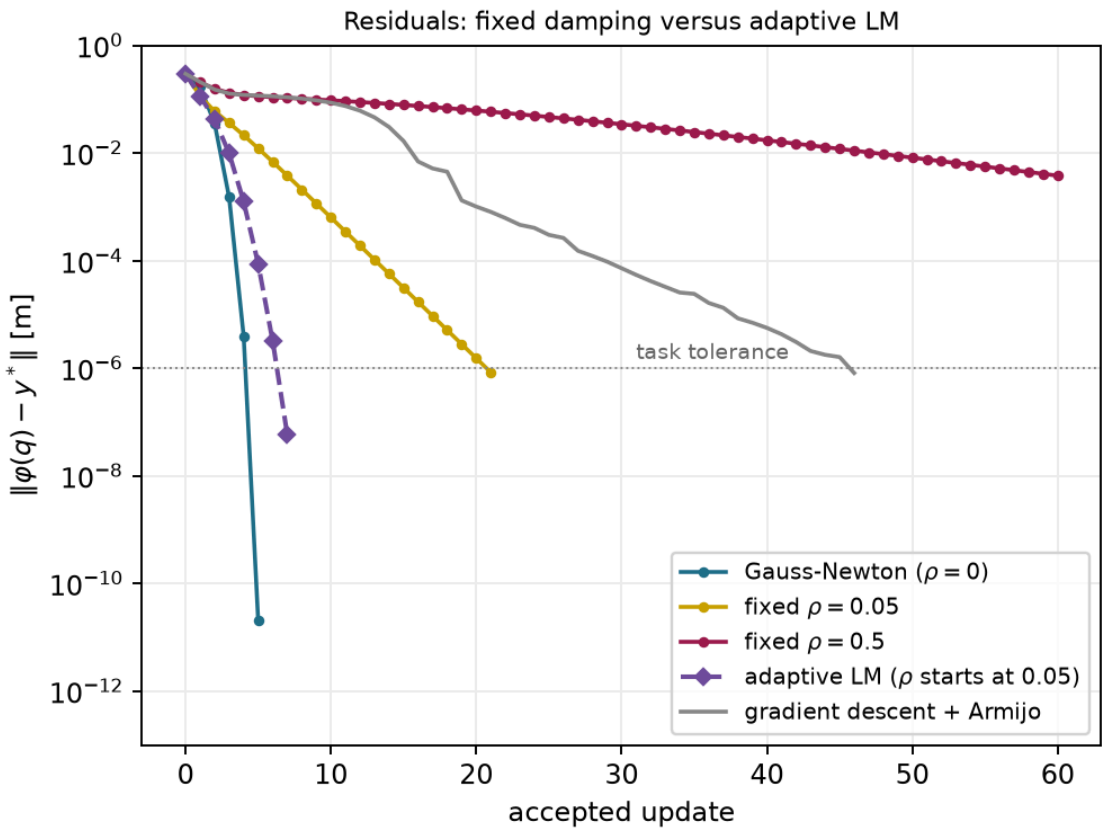
i	$\mathbf{q}$ (deg)	tip error (m)
0	(30.0, 45.0)	3.0×10^{-1}
1	(–22.7, 119.1)	1.7×10^{-1}
2	(–16.5, 84.5)	3.6×10^{-2}
3	(–11.5, 80.7)	1.5×10^{-3}
4	(–11.5, 80.4)	4.0×10^{-6}
5	(–11.5, 80.4)	2.0×10^{-11}

Five undamped Gauss–Newton updates from this start.

code/gauss_newton_ik.py · opt-explorer, lecture-arm IK ▶ run it live

Iterates and residuals



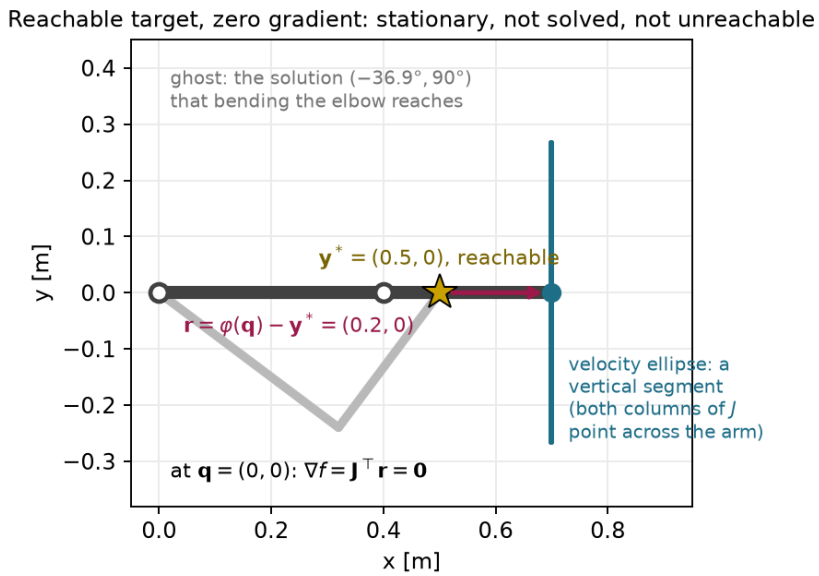


code/make_figures.py · opt-explorer, lecture-arm IK ▶ run it live

Stop, and say which of four things happened

outcome	test	meaning
solved	$\|\varphi(\mathbf{q}) - \mathbf{y}^*\| < \epsilon$	the target is reached to tolerance
stationary	$\|\mathbf{J}^\top \mathbf{r}\| \le \epsilon_g \|\mathbf{J}\|_F \|\mathbf{r}\|$ with $\mathbf{r}$ not small ($\mathbf{K} = \mathbf{I}$)	$\nabla f \approx 0$: the least-squares compromise if a minimum, or a bad stationary point
stalled	the line search halves α down to its smallest allowed value, the **floor**, and Armijo still fails	slow progress, not stationarity (next slide)
limit	the iteration cap, or a step too long to mean anything (diverged)	undecided

Stationary, **stalled**, and **limit** do not prove that the target is unreachable.



stretched arm, target on its own line

$\nabla f = \mathbf{0}$

gradient and Gauss–Newton updates are 0 here,

although bending can reach the target

$(-36.9^\circ, 90^\circ)$ reaches the target

code/gauss_newton_ik.py (p)

When the target is on the boundary, or beyond it

The two links can reach at most $0.4 + 0.3 = 0.7$ m from the base.

At maximum reach

$$\mathbf{y}^* = (0.7, 0)\ \mathrm{m}$$

- Reachable, with a straight arm
- Jacobian loses one motion direction at the solution
- Final convergence can be slower

Beyond maximum reach

$$\mathbf{y}^* = (0.8, 0.1)\ \mathrm{m}$$

- Target distance from base: 0.806 m
- Best possible tip error:

$$\|\mathbf{y}^*\| - 0.7 \approx \boxed{0.106\ \mathrm{m}}$$

opt-explorer · trajectory tab · lecture-arm IK ▶ run it live

Live demo: check the target geometry

Use the **trajectory tab** for both targets, from the same starting joints.

choose in Arm and goal	controls	observe
At reach boundary target $(0.7, 0)$ m	**Gauss-Newton step** ×4, then **Auto-play (GN)**	elbow angle, final corrections, tip error and stopping status
Beyond reach (damped) target $(0.8, 0.1)$ m	**Auto-play (GN)** preset damping $\rho = 0.01$	closest tip position, remaining error and stopping status

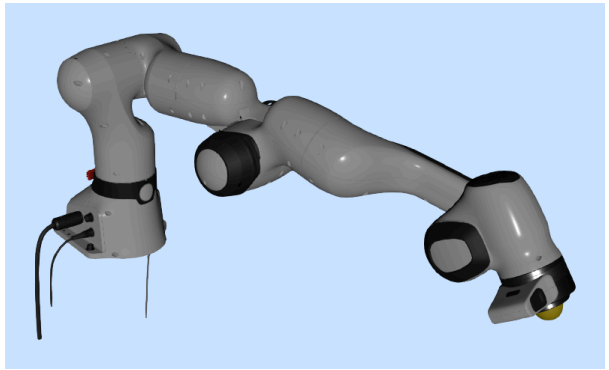
Compare the remaining error with the geometric prediction on slide 29.

opt-explorer · trajectory tab · lecture-arm IK ▶ run it live

A real arm: the Panda in Drake

- Position target: $\mathbf{J}$ is 3×7
- $\mathbf{J}^\top\mathbf{J}$ is 7×7 of rank 3: with $\mathbf{D} = 0$, infinitely many solutions; $\mathbf{D} = \rho\mathbf{I}$ or $\mathbf{J}^+$ picks one
- All four runs: $\mathbf{D} = \rho\mathbf{I}$ with $\rho = 10^{-3}$

run	start → target	line search	updates	what happens
1	ready → 10 cm sideways, 5 cm down	none	4	reaches the target
2	stretched → 5 cm along the weakest direction	none	**18**	reaches the target; error $\times 0.6$ per update
3a	stretched → beyond reach	none	40 (limit)	joints jump 0.9 to 4.2 rad; never settles
3b	stretched → beyond reach	**Armijo**	40 (limit)	still approaching; tip 0.246 m from the target



run 2, solved; target in gold

run 1, step i	residual (m)
0	1.1×10^{-1}
1	1.7×10^{-2}
2	3.7×10^{-4}
3	3.3×10^{-6}
4	5.0×10^{-8}

drake/02-gauss-newton-ik/gn_ik_panda.py ▶ run it live

Use previous steps to choose better directions

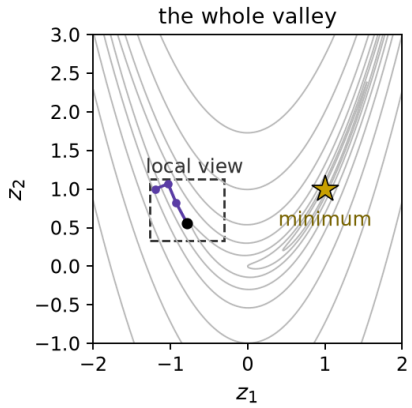
When computing a full Hessian is expensive:

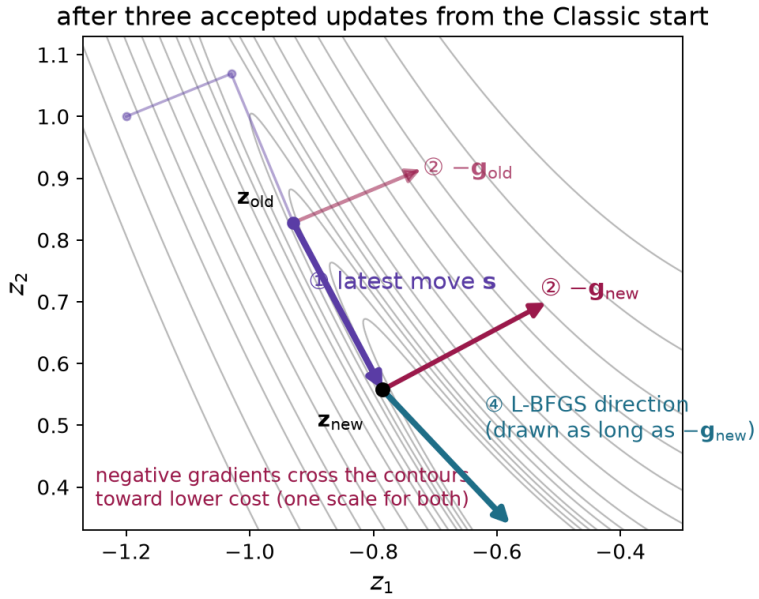
Method	What it reuses and why
BFGS	Gradient changes reveal curvature; no Hessian calculation
L-BFGS	A short history reduces storage for many variables
Nonlinear conjugate gradient	The previous direction helps guide the new one; little memory

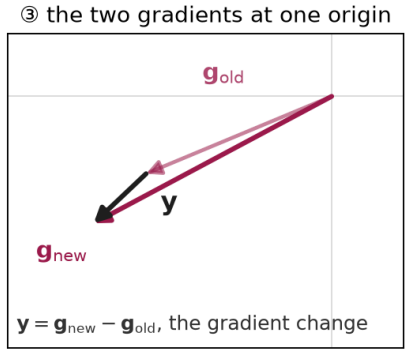
These methods choose a direction. A **line search** still decides how far to move.

Nocedal & Wright §§5–7 · opt-explorer ▶ compare directions

L-BFGS learns curvature from recent moves







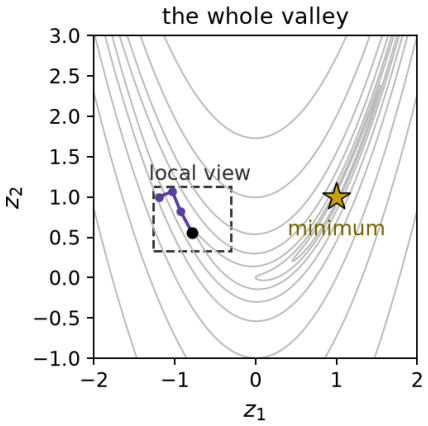
$$\underbrace{\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{z}_{\text{new}} - \mathbf{z}_{\text{old}}}_{\text{move}}, \qquad \underbrace{\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{g}_{\text{new}} - \mathbf{g}_{\text{old}}}_{\text{gradient change}}, \qquad \underbrace{\mathbf{y} \approx \mathbf{H}\mathbf{s}}_{\text{curvature information}}$$

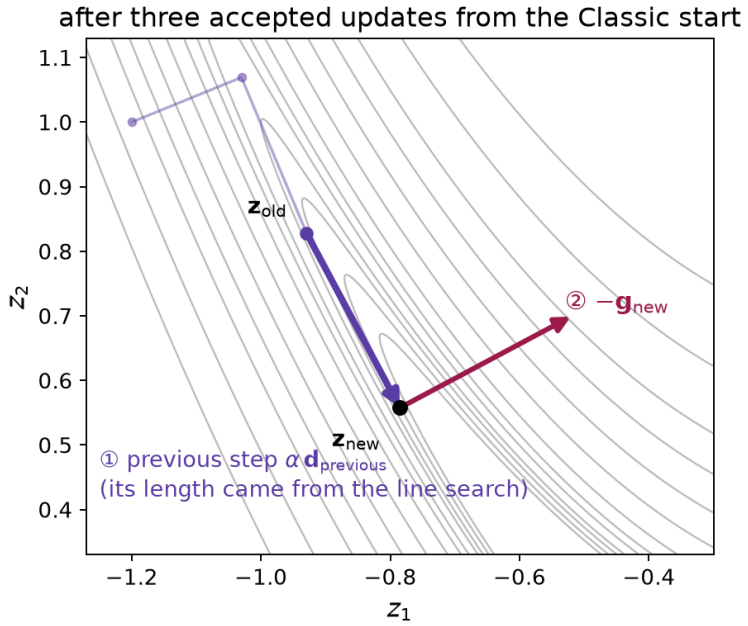
$$\mathbf{d} = \gamma\left(-\mathbf{g}_{\text{new}} + \frac{\mathbf{y}^\top \mathbf{g}_{\text{new}}}{\mathbf{y}^\top \mathbf{s}}\,\mathbf{s}\right), \qquad \gamma = \frac{\mathbf{s}^\top \mathbf{y}}{\mathbf{y}^\top \mathbf{y}}$$

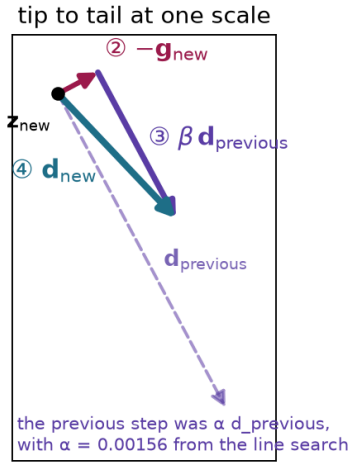
one stored pair, after an exact line search: rescale, then turn toward $\mathbf{s}$

code/history_directions.py · make_figures.py · the explorer's L-BFGS (m = 3) with the Exact line search ▶ run it live

Conjugate gradient reuses the previous direction





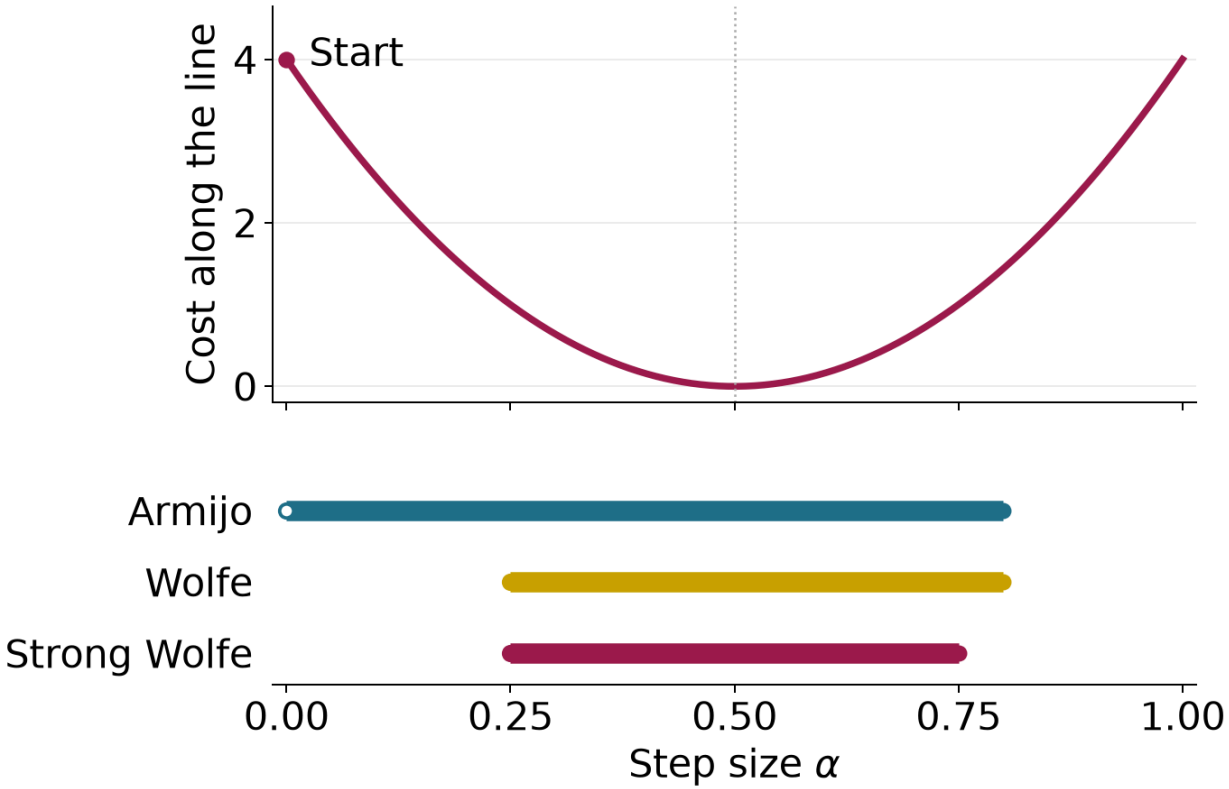


$$\mathbf{d}_{\text{new}} = -\mathbf{g}_{\text{new}} + \beta\,\mathbf{d}_{\text{previous}}$$

Both methods propose a direction; a line search decides how far to move.

code/history_directions.py · make_figures.py · the explorer's Polak–Ribière rule with its restart safeguards

A useful step must do more than lower the cost



Armijo: enough cost decrease

Wolfe: also reject steps that remain steeply downhill

Strong Wolfe: also reject slopes that are too steeply uphill

The bands show accepted step sizes along **one fixed direction**.

Nocedal & Wright §3.1 · opt-explorer ▶ **inspect the line search**

Summary of 3.2 answers slide 2's three questions

1. **How far should we move?**

   Damping discourages large updates. Armijo checks **actual cost decrease**.

2. **How do we handle more joints than task coordinates?**

   Damped least squares gives a **unique joint update**.

3. **What if the robot cannot reach the target?**

   Minimize the tip-to-target distance, even when it cannot become zero.

What Gauss-Newton does not know

- **Joint limits**: an elbow stop at $|q_2| \leq 60^\circ$

	$\mathbf{q}$	$\lvert q_2 \rvert$	result
elbow-up solution	$(-11.5^\circ, 80.4^\circ)$	80.4°	reaches the target; violates the elbow limit
elbow-down solution	$(55.1^\circ, -80.4^\circ)$	80.4°	reaches the target; violates the elbow limit
clip q_2 after each step	$(-16.4^\circ, 60^\circ)$	60°	stops moving **14.6 cm** off

Deck 05 finds the best allowed configuration, still 7.0 cm off.

- **Obstacles**: the tip-distance cost does not penalize collisions
- **Hard requirements**: "exactly here" versus "as close as possible"

Constraints, multipliers and KOMO come in **Deck 05 (4.1–4.2)**, and its solver runs the same Gauss-Newton step inside.

Same arm and target as slide 2 · opt-explorer ▶ **show elbow clipping**

Failure modes of the day

- **Tuning the step size by hand:** let Armijo choose each accepted step.
- **Capping the gradient step size too tightly:** with Armijo, **312 updates** for $\alpha \leq 1$ versus **46** when larger steps are allowed.
- **Taking large steps from a local approximation**
- **Confusing gradient descent with Gauss–Newton:**
  - Gradient descent: $\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\alpha \mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{r}$
  - Gauss–Newton: $(\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{J}_r)\boldsymbol{\delta} = -\mathbf{J}_r^\top \mathbf{r}$
- **Ignoring the remaining task error:** a small gradient does not mean the target was reached.
- **Mistaking line-search failure for convergence**

Backup slides

The main lecture introduces solver choices and line-search checks at a practical level. These backups retain the update formulas, detailed conditions and algorithms.

Backup · Wolfe conditions: Armijo plus a curvature check

$$(1)\ f(\mathbf{z}+\alpha\mathbf{d}) \le f(\mathbf{z}) + c_1\,\alpha\,\nabla f(\mathbf{z})^\top \mathbf{d} \qquad (2)\ \nabla f(\mathbf{z}+\alpha\mathbf{d})^\top \mathbf{d} \ge c_2\,\nabla f(\mathbf{z})^\top \mathbf{d}$$

- (1) is Armijo: enough decrease. (2) is **curvature**: the slope along $\mathbf{d}$ must have flattened enough; it rules out lazy tiny steps
- Strong Wolfe replaces (2) by $|\nabla f(\mathbf{z}+\alpha\mathbf{d})^\top \mathbf{d}| \le c_2 |\nabla f(\mathbf{z})^\top \mathbf{d}|$

typical constant	Newton and quasi-Newton directions	nonlinear conjugate gradients
c_1	10^{-4}	10^{-4}
c_2	0.9	0.1

Nocedal & Wright §3.1

Backup · Bracket and zoom

```
bracket:  α ← ᾱ ; repeat: if Armijo fails or f_d(α) ≥ f_d(previous): zoom(previous, α)
                          if |f_d'(α)| ≤ c₂ |f_d'(0)|: return α          # strong Wolfe met
                          if f_d'(α) ≥ 0: zoom(α, previous)
                          α ← min(2α, α_max)                            # grow
zoom(lo, hi): repeat: α ← (lo + hi)/2
                      if Armijo fails or f_d(α) ≥ f_d(lo): hi ← α
                      else: if |f_d'(α)| ≤ c₂ |f_d'(0)|: return α
                            if f_d'(α)(hi − lo) ≥ 0: hi ← lo
                            lo ← α
```

$f_{\mathbf{d}}(\alpha) = f(\mathbf{z} + \alpha\mathbf{d})$. Grow first to find an interval that must contain a Wolfe step, then bisect it.

Nocedal & Wright, Alg. 3.5–3.6

Backup · Steepest descent in a general norm

$$\mathbf{d}_M = \arg\min_{\mathbf{d}} \nabla f(\mathbf{z})^\top \mathbf{d} \quad \text{subject to } \|\mathbf{d}\|_{\mathbf{M}} = \sqrt{\mathbf{d}^\top \mathbf{M} \mathbf{d}} \leq 1 \qquad \Rightarrow \qquad \mathbf{d}_M \propto -\mathbf{M}^{-1} \nabla f(\mathbf{z})$$

- $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{I}$: gradient descent
- $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{H}$: **Newton's direction**, the steepest descent in the metric of the Hessian
- Newton's direction is gradient descent after a change of coordinates that makes the elongated bowl round, which is why conditioning does not slow it
- Any positive definite $\mathbf{M}$ is a **preconditioner**; a diagonal one costs $O(d)$ per step and can remove bad scaling of the coordinates

Backup · Quasi-Newton: BFGS and L-BFGS

Secant condition $\hat{\mathbf{H}}\,\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{s}$, for the step $\mathbf{s}$ and the gradient change $\mathbf{y}$:

$$\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{z}^{(i+1)} - \mathbf{z}^{(i)}, \qquad \mathbf{y} = \nabla f(\mathbf{z}^{(i+1)}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{z}^{(i)})$$

$$\hat{\mathbf{H}}^{(i+1)} = \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\mathbf{s}\,\mathbf{y}^\top}{\mathbf{y}^\top\mathbf{s}}\right)\hat{\mathbf{H}}^{(i)}\left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\mathbf{y}\,\mathbf{s}^\top}{\mathbf{y}^\top\mathbf{s}}\right) + \frac{\mathbf{s}\,\mathbf{s}^\top}{\mathbf{y}^\top\mathbf{s}}, \qquad \mathbf{d}^{(i)} = -\hat{\mathbf{H}}^{(i)}\nabla f(\mathbf{z}^{(i)})$$

- $\hat{\mathbf{H}} \approx \mathbf{H}^{-1}$ built from gradients only; stays positive definite if $\mathbf{y}^\top\mathbf{s} > 0$ (Wolfe guarantees it)
- BFGS costs $O(d^2)$ per step;
  L-BFGS stores only the last 5 to 20 pairs $(\mathbf{s}, \mathbf{y})$, at $O(d)$ per stored pair

`scipy.optimize.minimize`	picks
by default	BFGS
with bounds	L-BFGS-B
with constraints	SLSQP

modules/opt-explorer · Trajectory tab, preset "Three steps from one state" ▶ run it live

Backup · Conjugate gradients

```
g_old ← ∇f(z);  d ← −g_old
repeat:  α ← argmin_α f(z + α d)                  # (near−)exact line search
         z ← z + α d;  g_new ← ∇f(z)
         β ← max( g_newᵀ(g_new − g_old) / (g_oldᵀ g_old), 0 )     # Polak–Ribière
         d ← −g_new + β d;  g_old ← g_new
         if g_newᵀ d ≥ 0:  d ← −g_new                          # restart when the sum is not downhill
```

- A gradient-computed weight on the previous direction makes successive directions **conjugate**, $\mathbf{d}^{(i+1)\top}\mathbf{H}\,\mathbf{d}^{(i)} = 0$, without ever forming $\mathbf{H}$
- On a d-dimensional quadratic: exact minimum in d steps; memory $O(d)$
- Needs an accurate line search; sensitive to non-quadratic behavior